

The Phone Call Businesses Never Answer

AI phone agents: the missed-call business, at every scale.

62%

Calls to small businesses that go to voicemail or nowhere.

85% of those callers **never call back**. 62% call a competitor instead. One study, vendor-recycled — but every owner who hears it nods.

The caller doesn't wait around. The market quietly reallocates itself to **whoever happens to pick up.**

\$1.1B

ElevenLabs' valuation, Feb 2026
— ~\$500M ARR two months
later.

Vapi hit \$500M after Amazon Ring chose it over 40 rivals. Retell routes **50M+ AI calls** a month.

Platforms raise at software multiples to become infrastructure. Infrastructure needs **an installer** — in the dentist's office down the street.

The install, end to end

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- 01 **ElevenLabs — the voice**
The synthetic voice layer. This episode's narrator runs on it.
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- 02 **Retell or Vapi — the call logic**
Answers, qualifies, books. ~\$0.07–0.15 a minute.
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- 03 **Twilio — the number**
~\$1/mo plus usage. The phone line itself.
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- 04 **n8n — the handoff**
Calendar and CRM writes, with barely any glue code.
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- 05 **Cal.com — the booked slot**
The appointment the owner actually sees.

The voice narrating this week's episode is an AI voice — running on the same stack the episode covers. If you didn't notice, **that's the point.**

\$300–
700 / mo

**What a local business pays. Flat.
Plus \$500–2,000 setup.**

Priced as a receptionist replacement, **never as software**. Per-minute pricing is your cost line, not theirs.

\$1.5– 5K/mo

**Realistic year one, 3–8 clients —
an estimate, not audited results.**

No verified solo case study exists at scale. And the failure mode isn't the pitch — it's the **first embarrassing call**. 80% handled clean; the rest must escalate or the client churns.

The full breakdown is free.

The episode, the blueprint, every source and every number — link in the comments. One business you can build on your own, every week.

BUILD · OWN · OPERATE